The Sasmann Aesthetic

By Jules Tasca

DOCTOR: Would you please tell Mr. Sasmann to come in. (After a beat, Howard Sasmann enters. He is a well-built man who wears a pullover shirt and a pair of form-fitting white pants. The Doctor greets him) Howard Sasmann, I'm Dr. Bullock.

HOWARD: Good morning, Dr. Bullock.

DOCTOR: Good morning.

HOWARD: I was supposed to see a Dr. Eric Gutig, I believe.

DOCTOR: I'm his associate. Dr. Gutig's caught up in an emergency right now.

HOWARD: You mean the guy in the restraints who's yelling he's Jesus?

DOCTOR: We don't discuss other patients, Mr. Sasmann.

HOWARD: I understand a professional ethic, Doctor. But your Jesus is obviously mentally ill. I'm not. Let me clear that up right now. I don't really belong in a crazy house.

DOCTOR: Mr. Sasmann, this is a hospital, sir.

HOWARD: I stand corrected, Doctor. It is a hospital. All I'm trying to say is that there's nothing wrong with me.

DOCTOR: All right. But can we just talk for a while?

HOWARD: All talk all you like, but there's nothing the matter with me.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *The Sassman Aesthetic by Jules Tasca*

DOCTOR: Married?

HOWARD: No, I'm not.

DOCTOR: Girlfriend?

HOWARD: I date a couple of girls, yes. And they're both upset over this, too. It got into the papers.

DOCTOR: So I read.

HOWARD: I need to explain to them that there's nothing the matter with me. The papers made me into an evil person.

DOCTOR: All right. Then let me hear it from you. What are you doing here at Morrisville State Hospital?

HOWARD: You know what I'm doing here. You have my file.

DOCTOR: You tell me in your own words.

HOWARD: It was a deal. It was a deal my lawyer made with the judge. Coming here kept me out of jail. I agreed to come here as an outpatient to keep from going to prison. And I have to continue coming here until I'm deemed cured, Dr. Bullock. Does that correlate with what you have in that folder?

DOCTOR: It does.

HOWARD: And there's nothing wrong with me. Prison. That judge threatened me with prison. Oh, I don't say I don't possess the same quirks as every man, but psychologically, there's nothing wrong with me.

DOCTOR: Often . . . Often we perceive that nothing's wrong, Mr. Sasmann, because a person falls into a pattern of behavior that brings pleasure or security. But, in many cases, certain behaviors are . . . are destructive to a person's life and he or she doesn't see that if he . . .

HOWARD: It's not destructive. It's harmless. Harmless. And I lost my job over this harmless.

DOCTOR: You taught English at Community College.

HOWARD: Until I was arrested. And now I'm unemployed.

DOCTOR: Why do you think it's okay for you to go to the beach and . . .

HOWARD: It's harmless, I tell you. I've done it for years.

DOCTOR: And almost always have gotten away with it.

HOWARD: Away with what? Most of the girls smiled.

DOCTOR: But not all. And the judge called it assault, Mr. Sasmann.

HOWARD: It is not – not- assault, Doctor, to kiss someone. Assault. Jesus. There's nothing – absolutely nothing – violent about Howard Sasmann. I wouldn't know how to be violent. (He turns away from the Doctor, pause)

DOCTOR: Look, Mr. . . May I call you Howard?

HOWARD: (Turning back to her). Please . . .

DOCTOR: Howard, I don't know if most people would agree that what you're doing is acceptable.

HOWARD: Most people live in a narrow band of the spectrum of life, Doctor. I don't.

DOCTOR: Uh-huh.

HOWARD: Is that uh-huh agreement or disapproval? Most people . . .

DOCTOR: Howard, let's look at this realistically. You go to the beach and . . . and you . . . kiss women's buttocks . . .

HOWARD: Yes.

DOCTOR: Then you run off.

HOWARD: Run off. The way you say it. I just go on my way. Run off. You make it sound pathological.

DOCTOR: Then you say it. You tell me in your own words what this is all about. (Pause) Howard . . .

HOWARD: I . . I . . I like women's buttock s, Doctor. In my sexual map, a woman's buttocks are the main roads, thoroughfares and railroad lines. Do you understand?

DOCTOR: You're saying you have a fixation on a woman's . . .

HOWARD: Why do you make everything sound so clinical? Fixation. Come on, Doctor. In Africa, men are attracted to elongated lips. So much so that women

insert pieces of wood under the skin to stretch them even longer. In Japan, men prize a woman's neck and so dresses are designed to flatter and display a woman's neck. Here in the U.S., dresses are cut low and bras amply push up the mammary flesh for those men with a propensity for breasts. And on the beach, women wear thongs and bikinis, so that men who admire that anatomical splendor, a woman's rear, might partake of its beauty. Beauty, Doctor. Oh, God, when did beauty become pathology?

DOCTOR: Howard, you're correct. There's nothing wrong with a person, male or female, having a certain fetish, but in the case of . . .

HOWARD: There, you did it again.

DOCTOR: Did what again?

HOWARD: You're making it all sound like something from a medical case history. Fetish . . . fetish . . .

DOCTOR: A fetish is simply a . . .

HOWARD: I know what a fetish is, Doctor.

DOCTOR: Then go on. Tell me what it is. Why you feel this compulsion . . .

HOWARD: I suppose you can't think any other way. Compulsion. Now it's a compulsion. Your job is to make a malady out of every human whimsy that this repressed society looks askance at. Why is it a compulsion? Beauty attracts human beings. And, I might add, the most sophisticated of human beings. It's supposed to. You call that profound attraction a compulsion?

DOCTOR: You said you've been doing it for years and years . . .

HOWARD: Dr. Bullock, I've been shaving my face for years, too. And I've been eating corned beef on rye for years. I don't consider those actions to be compulsions. I like a clean shave, and I love the taste of corned beef, and when I go to the beach and I see – excuse me, Doctor, the perfect ass . . . I enjoy going up and kissing it. It brings me pleasure. It makes me excited

for my girlfriends. It's not a matter of compulsion, though it's compelling. It's not a fetish, but a defining female attraction. Dr. Bullock, try to understand, that to me the admiration of a tanned, oiled, shimmering derriere is a matter of . . . of . . .

DOCTOR: Of what?

HOWARD: Of aesthetics.

DOCTOR: Aesthetics?

HOWARD: Aesthetics. Yes. You know how a beautiful sunset captures the human eye simply because it's beautiful. You stop. You watch as the mighty wings of fire spread and float beneath the ocean's blue. It brings peace and tranquility. A woman's buttocks well formed is just another object of beauty on this earth: the firm rounded flesh where almost touching halves create the curved path of the split; the straight lines of the legs veering up to meet the delicate arcs; the tantalizing cross where the buttocks sensually crease atop the line of the thigh. Good God. It's the perfect human confluence of geometric forms in the body, Doctor. And when I kiss the anatomical precision, my kiss is a a salute to the wonderment of nature's sculptural handiwork. (Pause. Dr. Bullock stares at him a long beat.) Doctor? Dr. Bullock? Is something wrong?

DOCTOR: No. No, I . . . I understand what you're saying.

HOWARD: I'm sorry for getting myself all worked up.

DOCTOR: That's perfectly all right, Howard. You're giving me your perspective. I understand. You have this spontaneous desire to . . .

HOWARD: Desire . . . desire's okay. Yes, desire. I have a simple desire. . .

DOCTOR: Regardless of the terminology we use, Howard, you can't go to the public beaches and just . . . just salute women's buttocks as if they were the stars and stripes.

HOWARD: But you agree there's nothing wrong with me?

DOCTOR: People can't just go off and act out all the desires they have.

HOWARD: You didn't answer my question.

DOCTOR: I'm not a judge and jury. I'm a doctor. Just because you're more articulate than the average nuisance at the beach . . .

HOWARD: Nuisance?

DOCTOR: . . . doesn't change the fact that you're going to have to exhibit self-control.

HOWARD: I told you most of those girls smiled afterward, I swear to you, Doctor. It was just misfortune that this last time, the woman happened to be a lieutenant in the police department. Just my luck; a cop with a hall-of-fame rear end. Doctor, listen to me. For one question, can we be Howard and Grace?

DOCTOR: Go ahead.

HOWARD: Thank you . . . Grace . . . Grace, have you . . . have you ever looked at a man's body and seen some part of that body that attracts you? (Pause) Doc . . I mean, Grace?\

DOCTOR: How's this going to address your dilemma? Of course, women look at men's bodies and find them the object of . . . well . . . in fact, when I go to the tennis club, I see one fellow who must work out. He had an outstanding physique and I always look and . . and . . . and admire.

HOWARD: You see. You see.

DOCTOR: But I have the self-control not to go up to him in the middle of a forehand and kiss him.

HOWARD: Which part of this fellow's body attracts you the most?

DOCTOR: I'm Dr. Bullock now.

HOWARD: Okay. Okay. I'm sorry. I just wondered.

DOCTOR: So what else would you like to say? I have to write up a summary of this visit.

HOWARD: How many visits must I make before you consider informing the courts that my lips are no longer a threat to society?

DOCTOR: I can't say right now. But I do want to prescribe a tranquilizer.

HOWARD: A tranquilizer?

DOCTOR: It'll help calm the compulsion – sorry, but that's the nomenclature.

HOWARD: Doctor, com on. Tranquilizers?

DOCTOR: Just during the beach season, Howard, show the judge you're doing something. What am I going to report that we discussed – aesthetics? (She writes the prescription)

HOWARD: You're right. A prescription. The judge'll like that. This is a good idea. A prescription. I'll fill it and I don't even have to take it, right? I'll show the courts my pills. Yes. It's a good idea (She hands him the prescription). Thank you.

DOCTOR: You're welcome, Howard.

HOWARD: Two weeks . . . all right . . . two weeks . . . all the killers running loose and she handcuffs me on the beach and reads me Miranda. What a mess, Doctor.

DOCTOR: Now . . Now. . . don't worry. I think we can work this all out. (She pats his behind gently as she says this. He turns and looks at her.) I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I didn't mean to be familiar.

HOWARD: That's . . . that's all right. I understand (He smiles.)

DOCTOR: I don't know what came over me.

HOWARD: I'm not embarrassed.

DOCTOR: I apologize.

HOWARD: I said I understand. SO this guy at the tennis court then, you . . .

DOCTOR: (cutting him off) Two weeks, Mr. Sasmann . . . please . . . please . . . I have other patients . . . (Howard raises his hand as if to apologize for lingering and to say goodbye. Then he exits. She crosses downstage as the lights fade.) Holy cow, what came over me? What?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jules Tasca
Book: 35 in 10: Thirty-five Ten-minute Plays
ISBN: 1583422838
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 2005